

My Claude Usage Strategy

A personal reference for choosing the right Claude model and effort level, based on my profile as a student focused on coding, technical building, learning, research, and content creation (including the "60 Days of AI" series).

Recommended Primary Model

Claude Sonnet 5 — daily driver for ~80% of work.

Why This Model Fits Me

Strong coding ability, solid reasoning for learning and research, and fast enough to iterate without long waits. Opus is overkill for daily tasks and costs more; Haiku is too shallow for deep learning goals.

When to Use Haiku 4.5

- Quick syntax/fact lookups
- Fast formatting/cleanup of existing text
- Simple Q&A needing a fact, not reasoning
- High-volume, low-stakes tasks (e.g., generating many title variations)

When to Use Sonnet 5

- Writing and debugging code
- Explaining technical concepts for deep learning
- Drafting "60 Days of AI" content
- Most research questions
- General day-to-day building

Rule of thumb: if Haiku's answer would feel too shallow to use, or you'd need 3 follow-ups to get what you need, start with Sonnet.

When to Use Opus 5

- Architecting a non-trivial system (multi-file codebase, tech stack choices)
- Deep research with many moving parts or ambiguity
- Hard, multi-layered bugs Sonnet struggled with
- High-stakes content (a flagship series post)
- Complex strategic/career-prep thinking

Effort Levels

Level	Use for	Pair with
Low	Quick lookups, simple formatting, single facts	Haiku
Standard	Coding help, explanations, drafts, day-to-day research (default)	Sonnet

Level	Use for	Pair with
High	Multi-step coding, tricky debugging, careful research synthesis	Sonnet/Opus
Max	Architecture decisions, deep multi-source research	Opus

My Personalized Workflow

Task	Best Model	Best Effort	Reason
Daily coding (writing/debugging)	Sonnet 5	Standard	Fast, strong coding, cost-efficient
Hard bugs / new system design	Opus 5 / Sonnet 5	High	Needs deeper reasoning across more context
Learning a new concept	Sonnet 5	Standard	Clear explanations without overkill
Deep research (multi-source)	Opus 5	High/Max	Needs synthesis rigor and nuance

Task	Best Model	Best Effort	Reason
Quick fact/syntax check	Haiku 4.5	Low	Speed over depth
Drafting series content	Sonnet 5	Standard	Good creative + technical balance
Flagship/high-stakes series post	Opus 5	High	Worth the extra polish
Career prep (resume, interviews)	Sonnet 5	Standard/High	Needs judgment, not just facts
Business/growth strategy	Opus 5	High	Multi-variable strategic reasoning
Bulk/repetitive tasks	Haiku 4.5	Low	Volume over depth

Biggest Mistakes to Avoid

1. Defaulting to Opus for everything — slower and costlier; save for genuinely hard problems.
2. Using Haiku for learning — shortcuts depth when the goal is expertise.

3. Staying at Standard effort on hard bugs — bump effort instead of re-asking the same way.
4. Not iterating — treat first answers as drafts to question and refine.
5. Skipping effort tuning for high-stakes content.

Final Recommendation

If limited to ONE model and ONE effort level: Claude Sonnet 5 at Standard effort. It covers coding, learning, research, and content creation for the vast majority of work. Reserve Opus and High/Max effort as a deliberate step-up for hard debugging, deep research, or flagship content — not the default state.